

The New FACE OF PARLIAMENT

Younger, richer and with more women members than ever before, the profile of the Lower House offers hope that the forum could be an effective agency for positive change

| By Shafi Rahman |

Young, rich, successful and influential. Sounds like a perfect advertisement in a matrimonial column and it could well become one for many of the new MPs in the 15th Lok Sabha. The Rahul Effect, as many are calling it to give it the required traction, has resulted in a new-look Lok Sabha with a good-looking profile in most areas. It's certainly younger, for one. The number of parliamentarians below 40 years of age is 82, double the corresponding figure in the last Lok Sabha, which was largely seen as dominated by greybeards. The baby of the House hails from one of the farthest islands: 26-year-old Hamdullah Sayed from Lakshadweep. Ram Sunder Das, the 88-year-old MP from Hajipur, who defeated Lok Janshakti Party chief Ram Vilas Paswan, is the oldest member of the House. But the average remains a healthy mix of youth and experience.

The newly elected parliamentarians may be less rich in experience but certainly not in terms of

financial assets. There are an incredible 300 crorepatris in the new House, compared to 154 in the 14th Lok Sabha, which means that either long-serving MPs are getting richer pretty fast or new MPs are from the affluent strata of society. The new Lok Sabha also has the highest number of women MPs ever, 59, that is 14 more than the last House. In fact, the representation of women members has crossed the 10 per cent mark for the first time in Indian history which is a great boost for gender equality.

What is not such a positive change, however, is that the number of MPs with criminal records has gone up, from 128 in 2004 to 153 in 2009, a scary 28.6 per cent of the House. Whether they can hold the 15th Lok Sabha to ransom is still to be seen. Overall, however, the profile of the new Lok Sabha, and the mandate for stability, suggests that this could be a historic agenda for change, and a Parliament of the people and for the people.



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